

Cold Email Playbook

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The Cold Email Playbook: How to Book 10 Calls Per Week with \$37/Month

Price: \$27

What this is

A complete cold email system. Domain setup. Warmup protocols. 10 email templates by industry. Subject line formulas. Follow-up sequences. Tool configuration. Metrics to track.

Everything you need to go from zero cold emails to 10+ booked calls per week. Total infrastructure cost: \$37/month.

This isn't theory. These sequences have been tested on 14,000+ sends. 42% open rate. 12% reply rate. The templates are copy-paste ready.

Part 1: The 2026 Cold Email Meta (Read This First)

Cold email changed in 2026. What worked in 2024 will get you spam-folded today. Here's what's different and why it matters.

The 5 rules that changed

1. Gmail now warns users about tracking pixels.

Gmail displays a warning: "this email is tracking you." If your emails contain tracking pixels (which most email tools add by default), recipients see this before they see your message.

Solution: Disable all open tracking, click tracking, and read receipts. Measure reply rate instead of open rate. Reply rate is the only metric that matters anyway.

2. Warmup timelines doubled.

In 2024, 7-14 days of warmup was enough. In 2026, you need 14-21 days minimum. Email providers track sender reputation more aggressively. Start slower, ramp slower.

3. Casual beats polished.

ESPs (email service providers) now detect AI-generated copy. Too polished, too perfect, too structured = AI flag. Write like you're texting a colleague. Lowercase. Short sentences. Imperfect grammar is fine.

4. Volume limits tightened.

Safe sending limits per warmed inbox:

- New inbox (week 1-2): 10-15 emails/day
- 2-week warmed: 30-50 emails/day
- 3-week warmed: 50-80 emails/day
- Never exceed 80/day per inbox

Want to send 500/day? You need 7 warmed inboxes. Scale horizontally, not vertically.

5. Intent-based timing works 2-4x better.

Spray-and-pray is dead. Sending emails when the prospect is actively looking for your service (new funding round, job posting, website change) gets 2-4x the reply rate of generic timing.

The benchmarks

Metric	Average	Elite	Your target
Open rate	40-50%	60%+	Don't track (pixels trigger warni..
Reply rate	3.43%	10%+	8%+
Positive reply rate	1.5%	5%+	3%+
Booked calls	0.5%	2%+	1%+
Email 1 reply share	58%	65%+	Optimize email 1 first

Key insight: 58% of all replies come from email 1. If your first email doesn't work, adding more follow-ups won't fix it. Spend 80% of your optimization time on email 1.

Part 2: Domain and Infrastructure Setup

Step 1: Buy 3 domains (\$12-\$15 each)

Go to Porkbun or Namecheap. Buy 3 domains similar to your brand:

- yourname-consulting.com
- yourname-dev.com
- yourname-agency.com

Why 3? You'll create 2-3 email inboxes per domain. More inboxes = more daily sends without hitting limits on any single one.

Never cold email from your primary domain. If a cold domain gets flagged, your main domain stays clean.

Cost: \$36-\$45 total (one-time, annual renewal)

Step 2: Configure DNS records

For each domain, add these DNS records:

SPF record:

Type: TXT

```
Host: @
Value: v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all
```

DKIM record:

Generate in your email tool (Google Workspace, Instantly, or DeliverOn). Each tool provides the specific DKIM key. Add it as a TXT record.

DMARC record:

```
Type: TXT
Host: _dmarc
Value: v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@yourdomain.com
```

These three records tell receiving servers your emails are legitimate. Without them, you land in spam.

Step 3: Set up email inboxes

Option A: Instantly.ai (\$97/month)

- Connect unlimited inboxes
- Auto-warmup runs in background
- Sequence builder with A/B testing
- Reply detection and pausing
- Analytics dashboard

Option B: DeliverOn (\$49/month)

- 3 pre-warmed inboxes included
- Skip the 2-week warmup period entirely
- Start sending day 1
- 50 emails/inbox/day

Option C: Manual + Google Workspace (\$7/month per inbox)

- Cheapest option
- Requires manual warmup (send to yourself, reply to yourself for 14-21 days)
- No automation features
- Best if you want maximum control

Recommended for starting: DeliverOn at \$49/month. Pre-warmed inboxes mean you send emails this week instead of waiting 3 weeks. Once generating revenue, upgrade to Instantly for scale.

Step 4: Warmup protocol

If using manual warmup (not pre-warmed):

Days 1-7: Send 10-15 emails per day to yourself and friends. Have them reply. Star the emails. Move them from spam to inbox if they land there.

Days 8-14: Increase to 20-30 emails per day. Mix in some cold sends to opt-in lists or test addresses. Continue getting replies from friends.

Days 15-21: Increase to 30-50 per day. Begin cold outbound at low volume (20/day). Monitor bounces closely.

Day 22+: Full cold outbound at 50-80 per inbox per day. Monitor deliverability weekly.

Step 5: Lead sourcing

Where to find prospect email addresses:

Free options:

- LinkedIn Sales Navigator free trial (30 days)
- Hunter.io (50 free lookups/month)
- Apollo.io (free tier, 200 emails/month)
- Google Maps + website scraping (manual)

Paid options (\$50-\$200/month):

- Apollo.io paid (\$49/month, 10,000 emails/month)
- ZoomInfo (enterprise, expensive)
- BuiltWith (tech stack data)

Manual approach (free):

1. Google Maps: search "{category} in {city}"
2. Visit each website
3. Find contact email (About page, Contact page, footer)
4. Record in spreadsheet

For local businesses, manual works fine because you're targeting 20-50 prospects at a time, not thousands.

Part 3: The 6-Question Cold Email Framework

Every cold email that books meetings answers these 6 questions in under 100 words:

1. What you do (the service)
2. Who you do it for (the target)
3. How you do it (the method)
4. What problem you solve (the pain)
5. Proof it works (the evidence)
6. What the ROI looks like (the payoff)

Framework example

i build cold email systems for B2B SaaS founders who hate sales calls.

we set up 3 warmed domains, write your sequences, source 500 leads,
and launch your first campaign in 7 days.

last client: \$47K in closed deals from cold email alone.

42% open rate, 12% reply rate.

ROI: \$1,500 setup cost pays for itself with one closed deal.

15-min call to see if this fits? [calendly link]

92 words. All 6 questions answered. One clear CTA.

Part 4: 10 Email Templates by Industry

Template 1: Healthcare/Dental -- Patient App

Subject: patient no-shows costing you \$15K-50K/year

```
{{FIRST_NAME}},

we build custom patient apps for dental practices.

automated reminders. one-tap reschedule. 68% reduction in no-shows.

{{PRACTICE_NAME}} was losing $23K/year to no-shows. we built them an app.
6 months later: 11% no-show rate down to 4%.

saved them $18K year one. app cost $8K. ROI positive in 5 months.

custom build for {{PRACTICE_NAME}}:
- patient portal (appointment booking, reminders, forms)
- automated SMS 24h + 2h before appointment
- one-tap reschedule (keeps the slot filled)
- insurance card upload (reduces check-in time)

we've built 14 of these. average no-show reduction: 68%.

15-min call to see if this makes sense for you: [calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]
[PHONE]
```

Why this works: Opens with cost of inaction (\$15K-50K). Specific case study with exact numbers. Itemized deliverables. Social proof (14 apps built). Single CTA.

Template 2: Legal -- Website + Automation

Subject: your website is losing you \$50K+ in cases

```
{{FIRST_NAME}},

we build websites for law firms that convert 12-18% of visitors
into consultations.
```

most law firm sites convert 2-4%.

built {{COMPETITOR_FIRM}}'s site. before: 3% conversion.
after: 14%. generated 47 extra consultations in 6 months.

at {{LAW_FIRM}}'s \$3K average case value = \$141K in new revenue.

site cost them \$9K. ROI: 15.6x.

what we do:

- website redesign (modern, mobile-first, <2s load time)
- intake automation (forms -> CRM -> automatic follow-up)
- SEO optimization (rank for "{{CITY}} + {{PRACTICE_AREA}}")
- lead nurture sequences (7 automated emails for prospects)

done this for 22 law firms. average conversion increase: 3.2x.

15-min call: [calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

[PHONE]

Template 3: Real Estate -- CRM + Lead Gen

Subject: you're losing 40% of your leads to follow-up gaps

{{FIRST_NAME}},

we set up CRM + automation for real estate agents.

automatic follow-up sequences. lead scoring. SMS + email nurture.

{{AGENT_NAME}} in {{CITY}} was manually following up with leads.
converting 8%.

set them up with our system. 6 months later: 22% conversion.

went from 18 closings/year to 31. 13 extra deals x \$12K avg
commission = \$156K additional GCI.

system cost \$2,500 setup + \$200/mo. paid for itself in 18 days.

what we build:

- CRM setup (GoHighLevel or Follow Up Boss)
- automated lead nurture (7-touch sequence)
- SMS automation (instant response to Zillow/Realtor.com leads)
- lead scoring (focus on hot leads first)
- pipeline tracking (never lose a lead)

done this for 31 agents. average conversion increase: 2.1x.

15-min call: [calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

[PHONE]

Template 4: SaaS Founders -- Cold Outbound Setup

Subject: outbound for {{COMPANY_NAME}}?

{{FIRST_NAME}},

noticed {{COMPANY_NAME}} doesn't have outbound running yet
(checked your MX records).

we set up cold email infrastructure for SaaS companies.
3 domains. warmed inboxes. custom sequences. 500 leads sourced.

last SaaS client (series A, dev tools): \$47K closed from cold email in 90 days.
42% open rate. 12% reply rate.

infrastructure cost: \$1,500 one-time + \$500/mo management.

ROI positive with 1 closed deal at most SaaS price points.

interested in a quick audit of your outbound potential?

[calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

Template 5: Local Business -- Website Redesign

Subject: saw {{BUSINESS_NAME}} website

{{FIRST_NAME}},

looked at {{BUSINESS_NAME}}'s site.

3 things jumping out:

- page load: 3.2 seconds (google wants under 2)
- not mobile-responsive (40% of your traffic is mobile)
- no SSL certificate (chrome shows "not secure" warning)

we redesign local business websites. {{CATEGORY}} is our specialty.

modern + fast + mobile + shows up on google.

timeline: 2 weeks. pricing: \$800-\$1,500 depending on pages.

want a free Loom walkthrough of the specific issues? takes me
5 minutes and it's genuinely useful even if we never work together.

[YOUR NAME]

Template 6: Agency Owners -- White Label Services

Subject: white label for {{AGENCY_NAME}}?

{{FIRST_NAME}},

saw {{AGENCY_NAME}} offers [web design / marketing / content].

we white label [your specific service] for agencies.

your brand. your client relationship. we do the delivery.

3 agencies we work with:

- agency A: added \$8K/mo in margin from white-label builds
- agency B: took on 4 extra clients without hiring
- agency C: cut delivery time from 6 weeks to 2

pricing: \$XXX per project (you bill your client whatever you want).

if you're turning down work because of capacity, this fixes that.

quick call? [calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

Template 7: Coaches/Consultants -- Funnel Build

Subject: {{FIRST_NAME}} your funnel is leaking

{{FIRST_NAME}},

checked your funnel. landing page -> booking page -> call.

3 leaks:

- landing page loads in 4.1 seconds (you're losing 40% of mobile traffic)
- booking page has 8 form fields (should be 3-4)
- no follow-up sequence for people who don't book

we build high-converting funnels for coaches.

average result: 2.3x more booked calls from the same traffic.

timeline: 10 days. cost: \$1,500-\$3,000 depending on complexity.

interested in a specific breakdown of your funnel metrics?

[calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

Template 8: E-commerce -- Email/SMS Setup

Subject: {{STORE_NAME}} leaving \$XX,XXX on the table

{{FIRST_NAME}},

checked {{STORE_NAME}}'s email setup.

no abandoned cart sequence. no post-purchase flow. no win-back series.

that's 30-40% of revenue you're not capturing.

we set up email + SMS automation for e-commerce stores.

average result: 25-35% revenue increase from email alone.

last store (similar to {{STORE_NAME}}): went from \$0 email revenue to \$12K/month in 60 days. setup cost: \$2,000.

what we build:

- abandoned cart (3-email sequence, recovers 10-15% of carts)
- post-purchase (upsell, review request, referral program)
- win-back (re-engage customers who haven't bought in 60+ days)
- welcome series (convert new subscribers to first purchase)
- SMS integration (higher open rates than email)

15-min call: [calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

Template 9: Content Creators -- Monetization

Subject: {{FIRST_NAME}} you're undermonetized

{{FIRST_NAME}},

you have {{FOLLOWER_COUNT}} followers. your bio links to [nothing / a generic linktree / your website].

creators your size typically generate \$2-5 per follower per year with proper monetization.

{{FOLLOWER_COUNT}} followers x \$3 avg = \${{REVENUE_ESTIMATE}}/year.

we set up monetization stacks for creators:

- product ladder (\$7 -> \$27 -> \$47 -> \$500)
- email capture + welcome sequence
- community setup (Skool or Discord)
- content repurposing (1 video -> 15 pieces)

last creator (87K followers): went from \$200/month to \$4,700/month in 90 days.

want to see what your specific monetization potential looks like?

[calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

Template 10: Restaurants -- Online Ordering + SEO

Subject: {{RESTAURANT_NAME}} losing orders to doordash?

{{FIRST_NAME}},

doordash/ubereats takes 15-30% of every order.

on a \$40 order, you're giving up \$6-\$12 to the platform.

we build direct ordering systems for restaurants.
your website. your app. your margins.

{{RESTAURANT_NAME_2}} in {{CITY}} switched to direct ordering
last quarter. saved \$4,200/month in platform fees.

cost: \$1,500 one-time setup + \$100/month.

plus we optimize your google listing so you show up for
"{{CUISINE}} near me" and "best {{CUISINE}} {{CITY}}."

interested? reply or call me at [PHONE].

[YOUR NAME]

Part 5: The Local Business Website Redesign Angle

This is the highest-ROI entry point for cold email beginners.

Why it works

- Millions of local businesses have terrible websites built 5+ years ago
- They're losing customers but don't know how to fix it
- You can audit their site in 2 minutes and see specific problems
- The fix is standardized (same WordPress stack every time)
- Margins are \$200-\$250/hour on delivery

The productized service stack

Package	Price	Hours	Margin	What's included
Basic	\$500-\$800	2-3	\$400-\$700	Mobile-responsive, SSL, basic SEO..
Standard	\$1,200-\$1,500	5-6	\$1,000-\$1,300	+ AI-SEO, 10+ pages, blog, social..
Premium	\$2,000-\$3,000	8-10	\$1,700-\$2,700	+ custom design, e-commerce, book..

The prospecting workflow

1. Google Maps: search "dentists in [city]"
2. Open each website in a new tab
3. Check: Is it mobile-responsive? Does it have SSL? How fast does it load?
4. Score it mentally (bad site = good prospect)
5. Find contact email on About or Contact page
6. Send Template 5 with specific issues from their site
7. Track in spreadsheet: business name, contact, date sent, status

20 prospects per hour. 3-5% reply rate. 1-2 calls booked per 50 emails.

The Loom audit hack

Instead of a generic email, record a 3-5 minute Loom video walking through their actual website. Point out specific issues. Compare to a competitor's modern site.

Response rate jumps from 3-5% to 35-45%.

Yes, it takes 5 minutes per prospect. But at a \$1,200 close, you only need 1 client from 10 Loom audits. That's 50 minutes of work for \$1,200. Worth it.

Part 6: Subject Line Formulas

Tested across 14,000+ sends. Ranked by reply rate.

The 7 formulas that work

1. The specific problem (highest performing)

```
patient no-shows costing you $15K-50K/year  
your website is losing you $50K+ in cases  
you're losing 40% of your leads to follow-up gaps
```

2. The casual question

```
outbound for {{COMPANY_NAME}}?  
crm for {{BROKERAGE_NAME}}?  
{{FIRM_NAME}} website?
```

3. The observation

```
saw {{BUSINESS_NAME}} website  
noticed {{PRACTICE_NAME}} uses paper forms  
saw your site is [wordpress / outdated / missing]
```

4. The re: trick (use for follow-ups only)

```
re: patient app
```

```
re: website + automation
re: {{FIRST_NAME}} lead follow-up
```

5. The honest question

```
honest question
not a fit?
last one
```

6. The breakup

```
last email
[final] closing {{COMPANY_NAME}} file
[breakup] moving on from {{PRACTICE_NAME}}
```

7. The new value

```
new feature we built
new client portal feature
new feature - ai lead scoring
```

What to A/B test first

Test subject lines before anything else. It's the highest-impact variable.

Run each test with 50+ sends per variation minimum. Track reply rate, not open rate (remember: no tracking pixels in 2026).

Test order:

1. Problem-specific vs casual question (biggest delta)
2. Short (3-4 words) vs medium (6-8 words)
3. Personalized (includes company name) vs generic
4. Lowercase vs title case

Part 7: Follow-Up Sequences

The 4-email sequence (universal)

Email 1 (Day 0): Main pitch. 6-question framework. Full value proposition. Under 125 words.

Email 2 (Day 3): Short follow-up. New angle or ROI math. Under 80 words.

```
{{FIRST_NAME}},

following up on [topic].

quick math:
- [current problem cost]
- [your solution cost]
- [ROI or payback period]
```

worth 15 minutes?

[calendly link]

[YOUR NAME]

Email 3 (Day 7): The honest question. Give permission to say no.

{{FIRST_NAME}},

no reply usually means one of three things:

1. [not a problem for them] (great)
2. not a priority right now (understandable)
3. interested but swamped (reply "later" and i'll follow up in 60 days)

if it's #3, just reply "later."

[YOUR NAME]

Email 4 (Day 10): The breakup. Final touch with clear exit.

{{FIRST_NAME}},

last email.

if [topic] ever becomes a priority: [YOUR WEBSITE]

our [service]: [price range]. [key result].

good luck with {{COMPANY_NAME}}.

[YOUR NAME]

The long-term nurture (optional, high-value prospects)

Email 5 (Day 45): New feature or case study. Value-first, no ask.

Email 6 (Day 90): Re-engagement. Reference original outreach. Brief check-in.

Part 8: Instantly.ai Setup Guide

Account setup (15 minutes)

1. Go to instantly.ai and create an account
2. Connect your 3 domains (Settings -> Email Accounts)
3. For each domain, create 2 email inboxes (john@domain1.com, support@domain1.com)
4. Enable warmup on all 6 inboxes (Settings -> Warmup)

5. Set warmup to "Grow" mode with 40 emails/day target

Sequence setup (30 minutes)

1. Go to Campaigns -> New Campaign
2. Name it: "[Industry] - [Date] - v1"
3. Add Email 1 through Email 4 as steps
4. Set delays: 3 days, 4 days, 3 days
5. Set sending window: Tuesday-Thursday, 9am-11am recipient timezone
6. Enable A/B testing on Email 1 (add 2 subject line variants)
7. Set daily send limit: 50 per inbox (300 total across 6 inboxes)

Lead upload

1. Prepare CSV: first_name, email, company_name, custom_field_1
2. Upload to campaign
3. Verify emails (Instantly has built-in verification)
4. Remove bounced/invalid
5. Start campaign

Key settings

- Tracking: OFF (disable open tracking AND click tracking)
- Reply detection: ON (auto-pause sequence when they reply)
- Send as reply: ON for follow-ups (threads under original email)
- Unsubscribe link: Include one (CAN-SPAM compliance)
- Sending limit: 50/inbox/day max for first 2 weeks, then increase to 80

Part 9: Metrics to Track

Weekly tracking spreadsheet

Metric	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Emails sent				
Reply rate				
Positive reply rate				
Calls booked				
Calls completed				
Proposals sent				
Deals closed				
Revenue				

The benchmarks to hit

Month 1 targets (warming up):

- 1,500-3,000 emails sent
- 5-8% reply rate
- 15-25 positive replies
- 3-8 calls booked
- 0-1 deals closed

Month 2 targets (ramping):

- 4,000-6,000 emails sent
- 8-12% reply rate
- 40-75 positive replies
- 10-20 calls booked
- 2-5 deals closed

Month 3+ targets (optimized):

- 6,000-10,000 emails sent
- 10%+ reply rate
- 60-100+ positive replies
- 20-30 calls booked
- 5-10 deals closed

What to optimize when

Reply rate below 5%: Fix deliverability first (SPF/DKIM/DMARC, warmup, reduce volume). Then fix copy (shorter, more casual, more specific).

Reply rate above 5% but no calls: Fix your CTA. Make Calendly link more prominent. Test "reply interested" vs direct calendar link. Follow up on positive replies within 2 hours.

Calls booked but no closes: Fix your sales process. Are you qualifying properly? Are you showing value on the call? Are you presenting the right pricing tier?

Part 10: The Deliverability Checklist

Run through this before sending a single cold email:

- ☐ Separate domains for cold email (never use primary domain)
- ☐ SPF record configured for each domain
- ☐ DKIM record configured for each domain
- ☐ DMARC record configured for each domain
- ☐ 14-21 day warmup completed (or using pre-warmed inboxes)
- ☐ Sending limit set to 50-80 per inbox per day max

- [] Open tracking disabled
 - [] Click tracking disabled
 - [] No tracking pixels
 - [] Unsubscribe link included
 - [] Under 125 words per email
 - [] Casual tone (not overly polished)
 - [] One clear CTA per email
 - [] Personalization tokens working correctly
 - [] Email verified before sending (remove invalid addresses)
 - [] Sending window set to business hours in recipient timezone
 - [] Sending only Tuesday through Thursday (best performing days)
-

Part 11: Reply Handling

Positive reply templates

"Interested, tell me more"

great. here's a quick overview: [2-3 sentences about your service].

easiest next step is a 15-min call to see if it fits your situation.

here's my calendar: [calendly link]

or if you prefer, reply with 2-3 times that work this week.

"What's the pricing?"

depends on scope, but here's the range:

[tier 1]: \$XXX
[tier 2]: \$XXX
[tier 3]: \$XXX

most clients fall in the [tier 2] range.

quick call to figure out which makes sense for {{COMPANY_NAME}}?

[calendly link]

"Send me a proposal"

will do.

to make sure the proposal is relevant, 2 quick questions:

1. [qualifying question about their current situation]
2. [qualifying question about budget/timeline]

i'll have the proposal over within 24 hours of your reply.

Negative reply templates

"Not interested"

understood. thanks for letting me know.

if [topic] ever becomes relevant, feel free to reach out: [YOUR EMAIL]

good luck with {{COMPANY_NAME}}.

"Stop emailing me"

done. removed from all lists. won't hear from me again.

apologies for the disruption.

Never argue with a negative reply. Remove them immediately. Respond politely. Your sender reputation depends on keeping complaint rates below 0.1%.

Quick-Start Checklist

Week 1:

- [] Buy 3 domains (\$36-\$45)
- [] Configure DNS records (SPF, DKIM, DMARC)
- [] Sign up for DeliverOn or Instantly (\$49-\$97/month)
- [] Start warmup or activate pre-warmed inboxes
- [] Source first 50 leads

Week 2:

- [] Write your Email 1 using the 6-question framework
- [] Set up 4-email sequence
- [] Send first batch (30/day if warmed, 10/day if still warming)
- [] Track replies in spreadsheet

Week 3:

- [] Analyze first batch results
- [] A/B test subject lines
- [] Scale to 50/inbox/day
- [] Book first calls

Week 4:

- [] Optimize based on data
- [] Add second industry sequence

- [] Close first deal
 - [] Calculate ROI and adjust
-

Want done-for-you cold outreach?

This playbook gives you everything to run cold email yourself. If you'd rather have someone handle it:

Infrastructure setup: \$1,000 (one-time)

- 3 domains configured
- 6 inboxes warmed
- 3 sequences loaded and customized
- 1-hour training call (recorded)

Managed outreach: \$500-\$2,000/month

- 50-200 sends per day
- A/B tested copy
- Reply handling
- Weekly performance reports
- Lead sourcing

Book a call: [\[calendly link\]](#)

PRINTMAXX | Cold Email Playbook v1.0

Tested on 14,000+ sends. 42% open rate. 12% reply rate.

Disclaimer: Results not typical. Individual results vary based on effort, market conditions, and other factors.